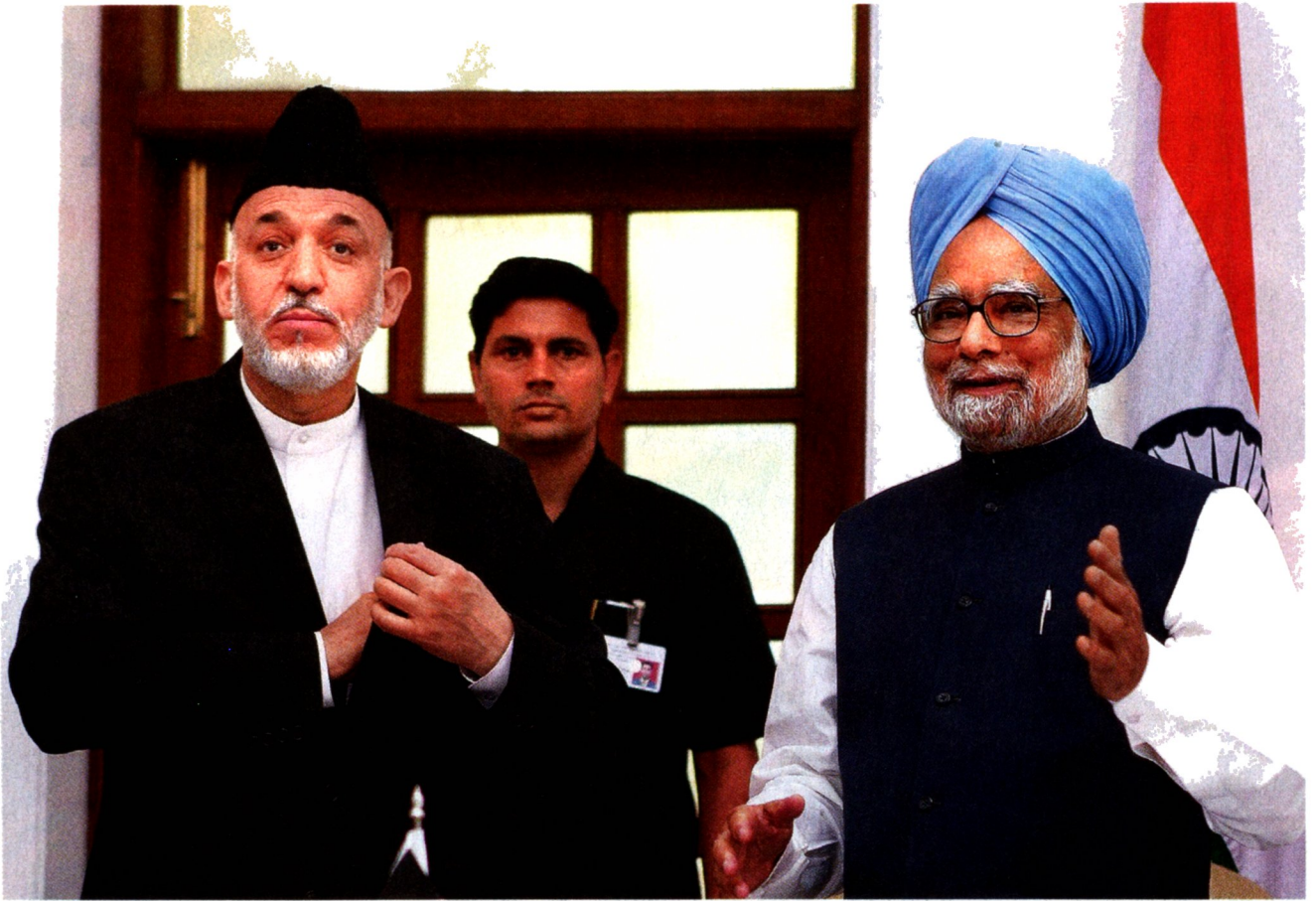




DELHI | The Karzai Card

In the middle of a stormy Parliament session, India rolled out a soothing red carpet to embattled Afghanistan President Hamid Karzai. It was all a way of ensuring strategic depth in Afghanistan with Karzai being quick to allay fears on the security of Indians in Afghanistan, saying that his country will not turn into a safe haven for terrorists. For his part, undeterred by a string of suicide attacks in Kabul targeting Indians, Manmohan assured the Afghan leader that India will continue to help his people. Indian projects in Afghanistan include the completed Pul-e-Khumri electricity transmission line to Kabul and the construction of a new Afghan Parliament. Karzai's visit was more about the symbolism of proving a point, realising well it would not go down too well in some Western capitals, including Washington, which no longer trust the Afghan president. Regardless of that particular sentiment, India went ahead with the visit sending out a message that it would engage first and foremost, in its own national interest. Delhi realises that after being elbowed out by the US on its Af-Pak policy, its best judgement lies in ensuring its political and strategic presence in Afghanistan, for which Karzai is vital. In return, the Afghan President gets a greater degree of legitimacy when an important global player like India stands by him in times of trouble. That is something a good Pashtun rarely forgets.

by Saurabh Shukla

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billion dollars of aid is being provided to Kabul by Delhi even as 4,000 Indians continue to work in Afghanistan.

KARZAI AND
MANMOHAN
IN DELHI